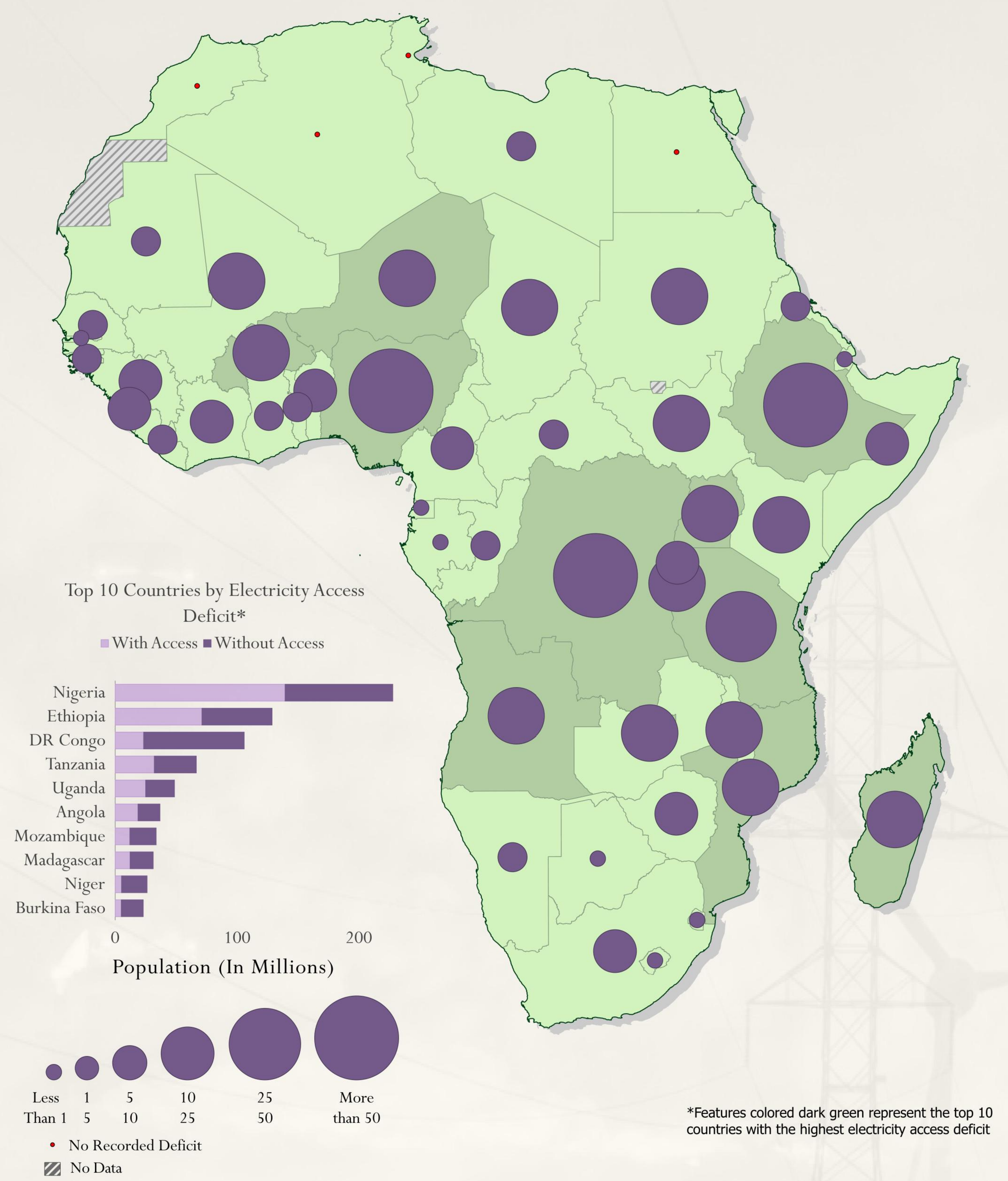
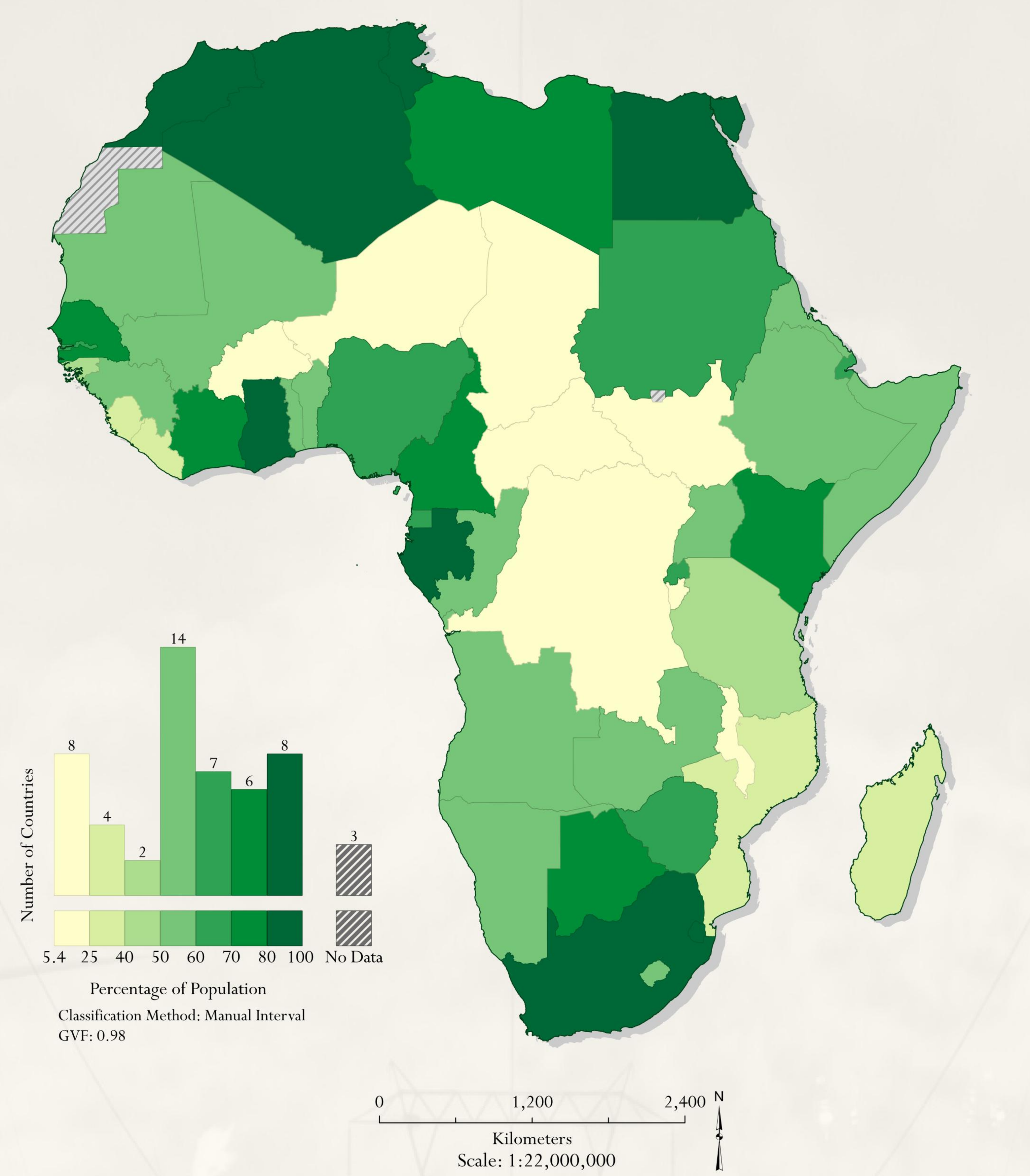
ELECTRICITY ACCESS RATE IN AFRICA FOR 2023

Population Without Access



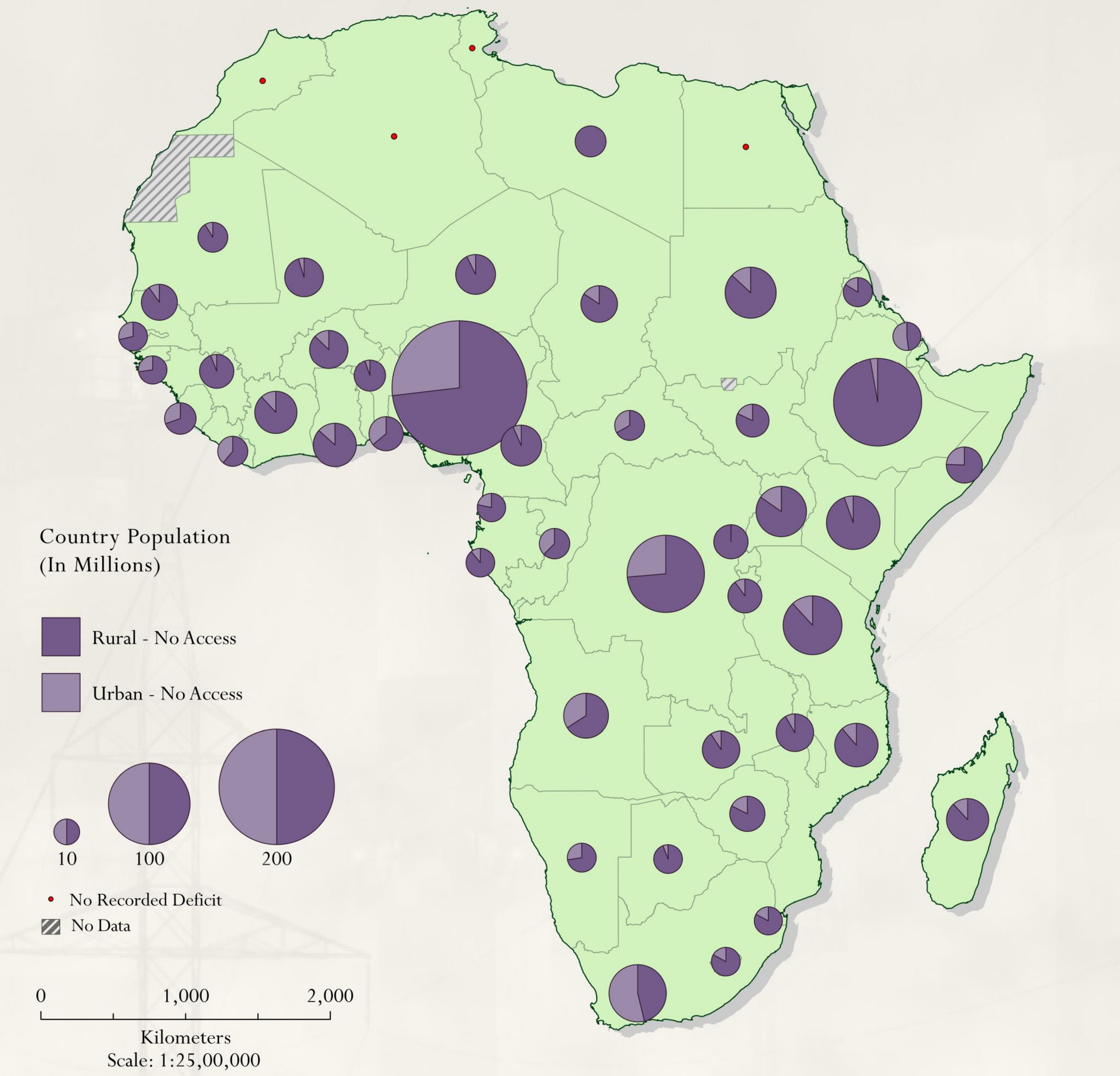
Electricity access deficit refers to the number of people who do not have access to electricity. The largest deficits are concentrated in a few high-population countries, with Nigeria showing the largest gap by far, followed by Ethiopia and the Democratic Republic of Congo.

Percentage of Population With Access



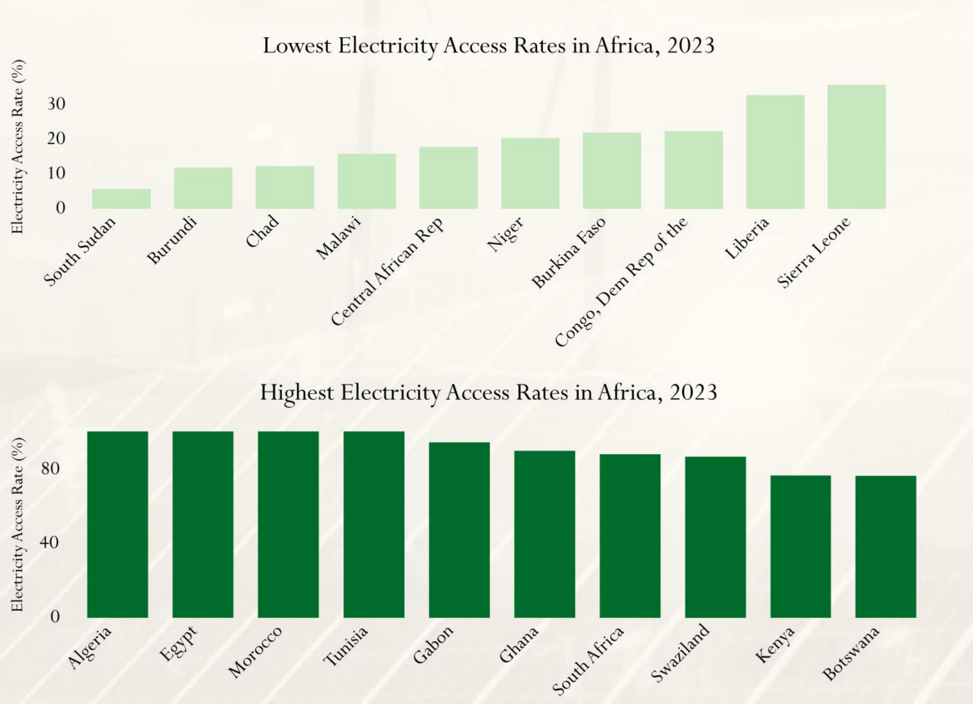
Access rates vary sharply across the continent. North Africa and parts of Southern Africa exceed 80%, while a band of Central and West African countries remain below 40%. The distribution is bimodal: a large cluster of countries above 80% access, and a second cluster below 25%, with comparatively few in between.

Urban vs. rural split



Even where national access rates look reasonable, the rural gap remains severe. Across Sub-Saharan Africa, roughly 83% of urban residents have power compared to just 33% of rural residents, a gap the national rate alone hides completely.

A 96-Point Gap: Africa's Most and Least Electrified Countries



Egypt, Algeria, Morocco and Tunisia lead the continent at 100% access, South Sudan report access rates below 6%, a gap of roughly 94 percentage points between the most and least electrified countries in Africa.

One Variable, Five Viewpoints

Africa's electricity access rate has improved a lot since 2010, but one continental average does not show the full situation. At the country level, access is close to universal in much of North Africa, while it remains below 25 percent in some parts of Central Africa. When the issue is measured by the total number of people without electricity instead of by percentage, the pattern changes. Large countries with moderate access rates, such as Nigeria, can have deficits almost as large as countries with very low access rates, such as the Democratic Republic of the Congo, because their populations are much larger.

The same problem appears within individual countries. In Nigeria, state-level data shows a clear north-south divide that is hidden by the national average. The urban and rural comparison also reveals another important difference. Even countries with fairly strong national access rates can still have a serious rural electricity gap. Overall, these five viewpoints show that electricity access in Africa cannot be described accurately with only one map or one overall number.

Africa's Electricity Access: The Numbers

580M+ people without electricity access

Continental access rate has risen from about 45% (2010) to roughly 60%+ today.

Urban access (about 83%) is more than double rural access (about 33%) across Sub-Saharan Africa

Roughly 20 of the world's 24 highest-deficit countries are in Africa

Nigeria and DR Congo each account for tens of millions without power, for very different reasons.

Closing the Gap

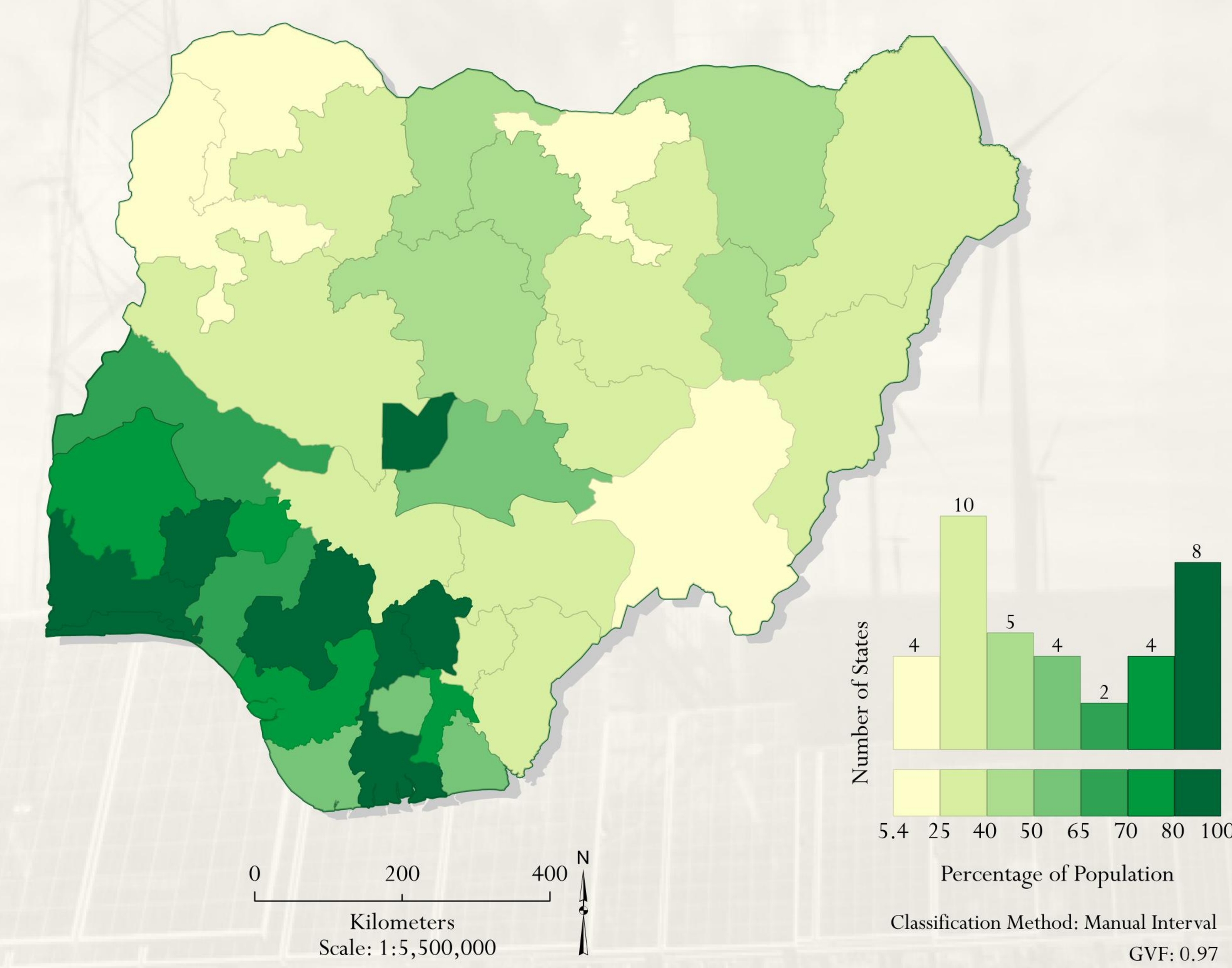
The World Bank/African Development Bank's Mission 300 initiative aims to connect 300 million Africans by 2030.

Off-grid solar and mini-grids are expanding fastest in areas the main grid hasn't reached.

National electrification strategies increasingly target rural areas specifically, not just urban expansion.

Countries with lower access but strong hydro potential, such as DR Congo, illustrate that generation capacity and delivered access are two separate problems requiring separate investment.

Nigeria, state-level access rate



Nigeria's national rate conceals a sharp internal divide. Northern states report electrification well below the national average, while southern and urbanized states approach universal access, a pattern the country-level map cannot show.

Date: July 20, 2026
Cartographers: John Abboud & Delu Maduekwe
Sources: World Bank/ESMAP, Tracking SDG7 (2024); World Bank Open Data; USAID DHS Program, Nigeria; geoBoundaries (Runfola et al., 2020)

Projections: Africa Albers Equal Area (African Continent), WGS 1984 UTM Zone 32N (Nigeria)
Disputed territories (Western Sahara, Abyei) are shown as No Data and imply no opinion on political status. Small island states are excluded due to overlap at this scale.